

Openness Matters: Source and Interfaces in the Age of Agents

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Outline

1. ☐ Openness Is Strategic [4]
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AI Success Is Not About AI



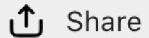
AI Integration Is the New Moat

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By [Tim O'Reilly](#)

October 27, 2025 • 6 minute read

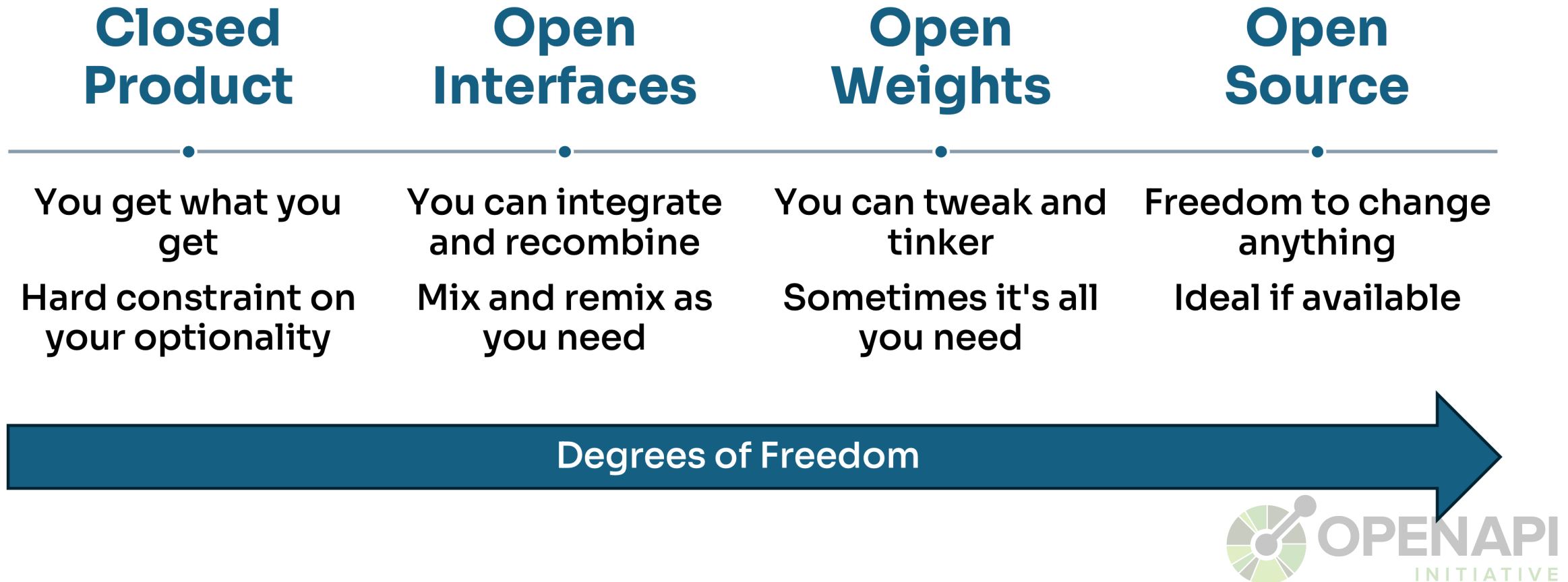


Share

The electrical system warning light had gone on in my Kona EV over the weekend, and all the manual said was to take it to the dealer for evaluation. I first tried scheduling an appointment via the website, and it reminded me how the web, once a marvel, is looking awfully clunky these days. There were lots of options for services to schedule, but it wasn't at all clear which of them I might want.



Integration Needs Something to Integrate



Everybody Is Somebody's Dependency

- The openness of *what you use* is a preference and not something you control
- The openness of *how you consume* is architecture and fully yours
- The first is one input among many
- The second is a strategy matter
- Openness matters to your consumers the same way it matters to you

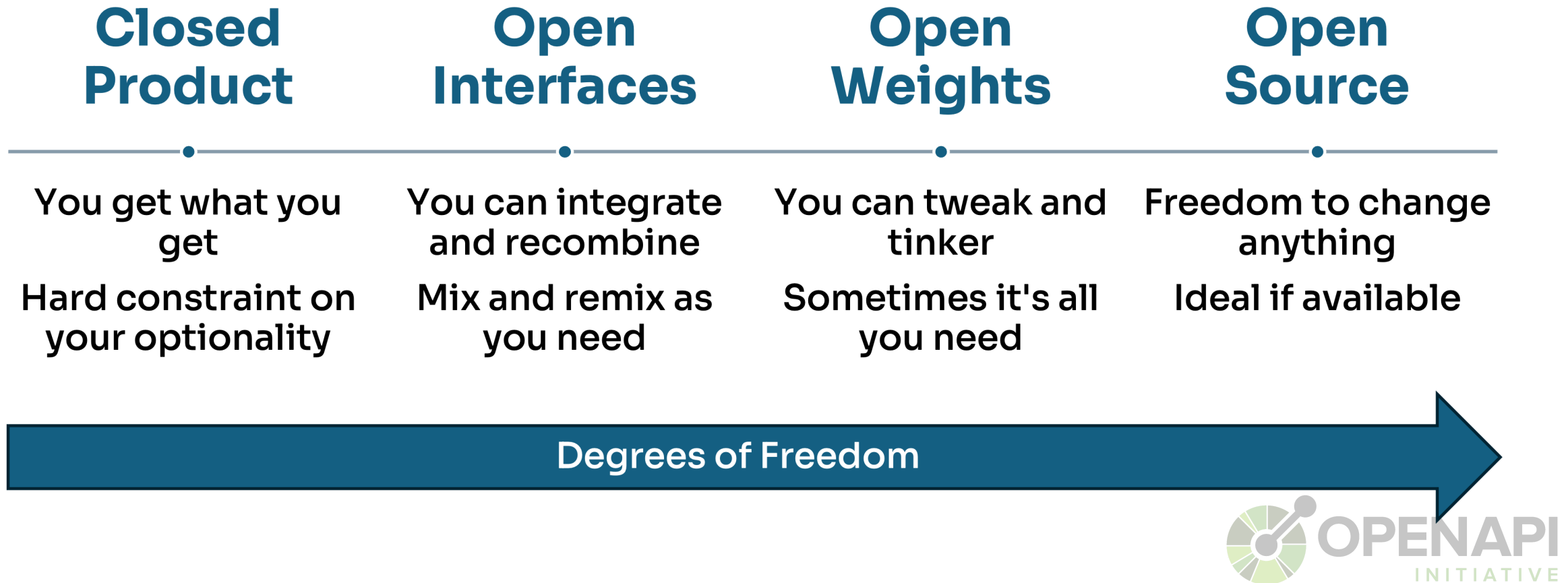


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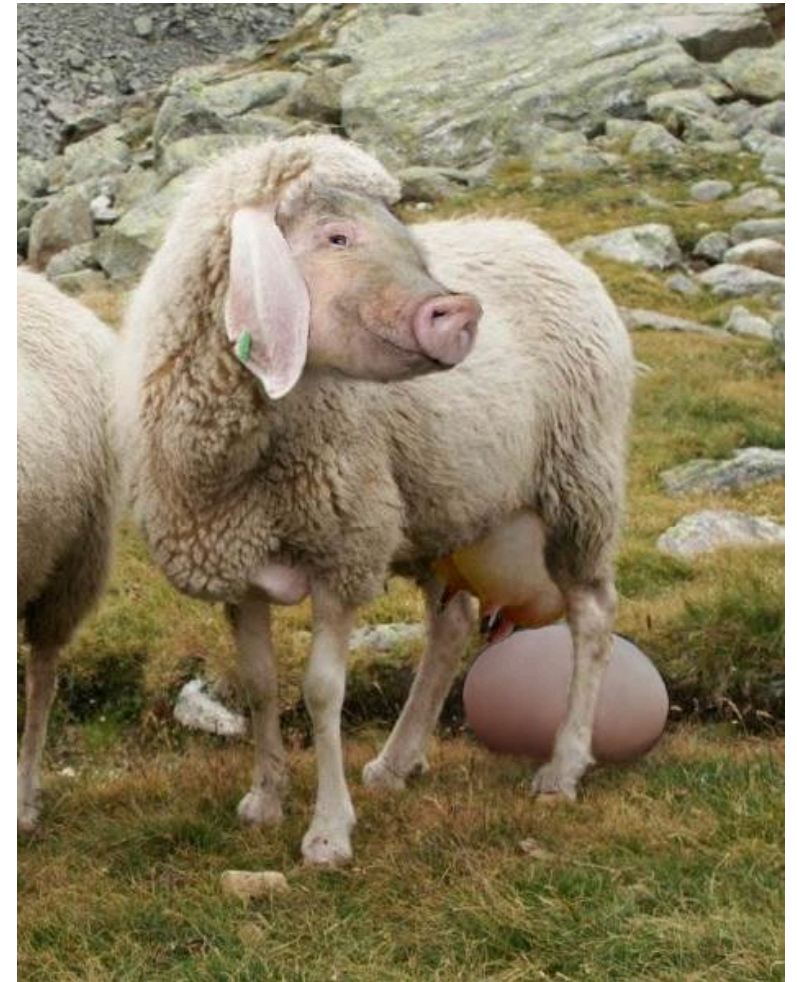


Where Your Models Sit



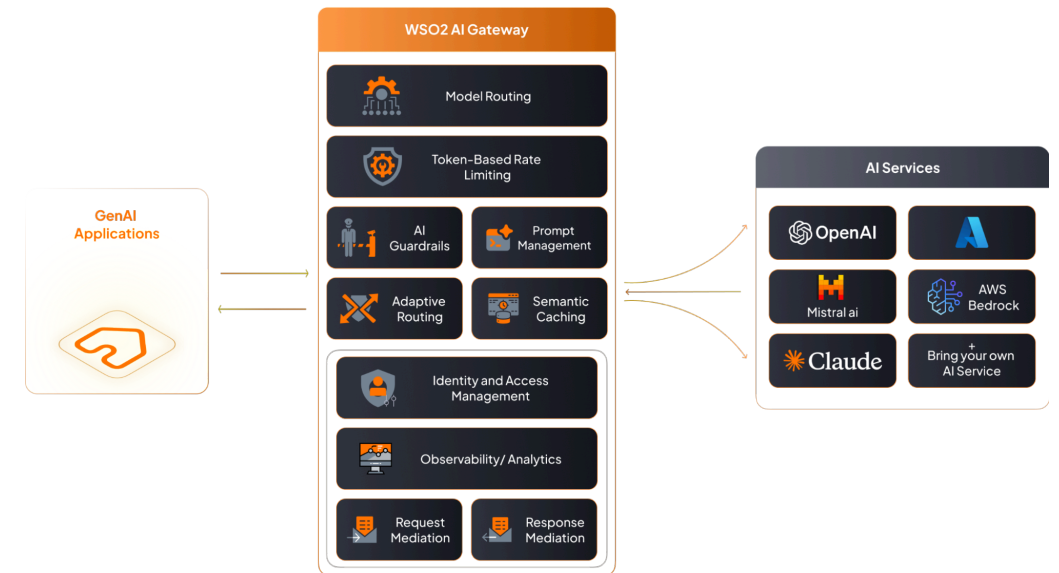
Not Every Task Needs the Frontier

- Open models now lag the frontier by a few months
- Most (business) agent tasks never needed a frontier model
- Running models locally changes cost and data exposure
- Mixing and tweaking models becomes a real option



Many Models, One Interface

- A portfolio of models replaces picking one winner
- A gateway is the interface to the model layer
- Models can be switched without touching applications
- Controls, limits, and monitoring end up in one place



AI Is an Implementation Detail

- As little AI as possible and as much AI as necessary
- AI is an implementation detail of a capability
- Stable interfaces keep the capability separate from its implementation

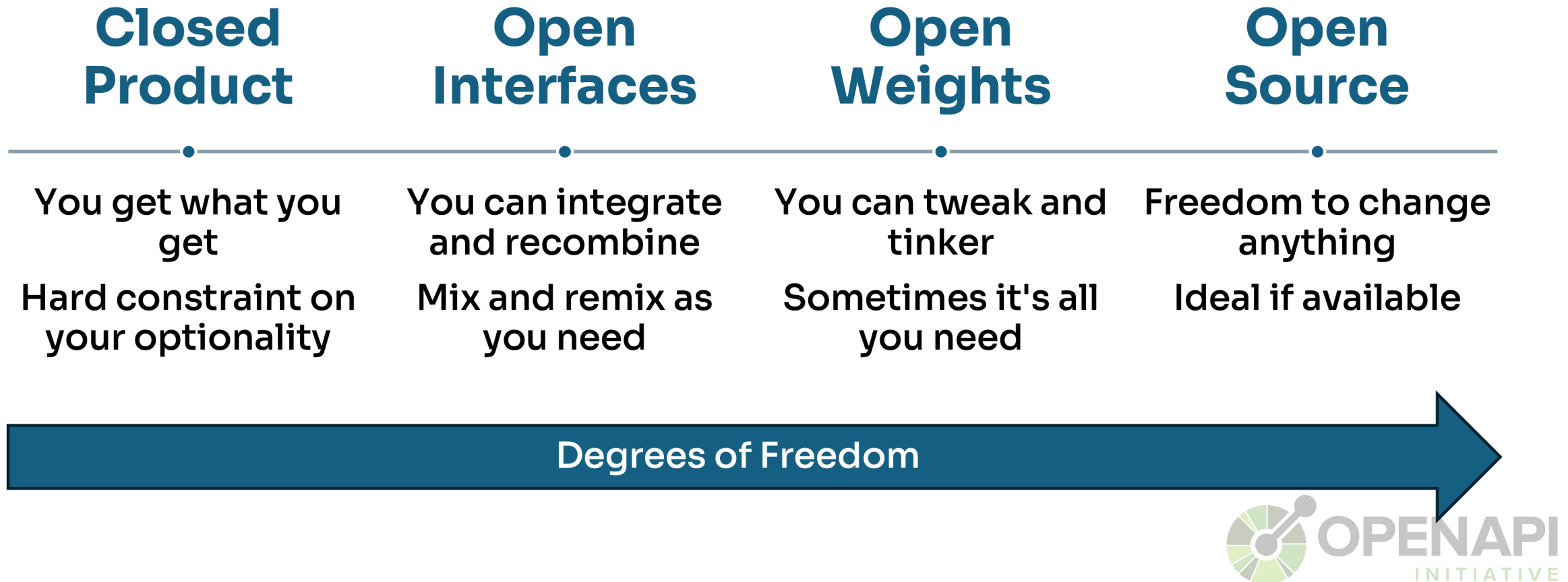


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Where You Sit



BYOA: Bring Your Own Agent

- Agents consume your APIs whether you planned for it or not
- APIs were typically consumed by developers
- Developers write code that *often fills DX gaps*
- LLMs have more limited context than developers
 - *Coding agents* shouldn't depend on developers selecting APIs
 - *Business agents* need to fully “understand” APIs

WE 
BYO



Humans Tolerate, Machines Cannot

- No clear indications when to (not) use
- Vague/minimal descriptions of behavior
- Inconsistent naming
- Missing authentication info
- Missing examples
- Missing or unhelpful error messages

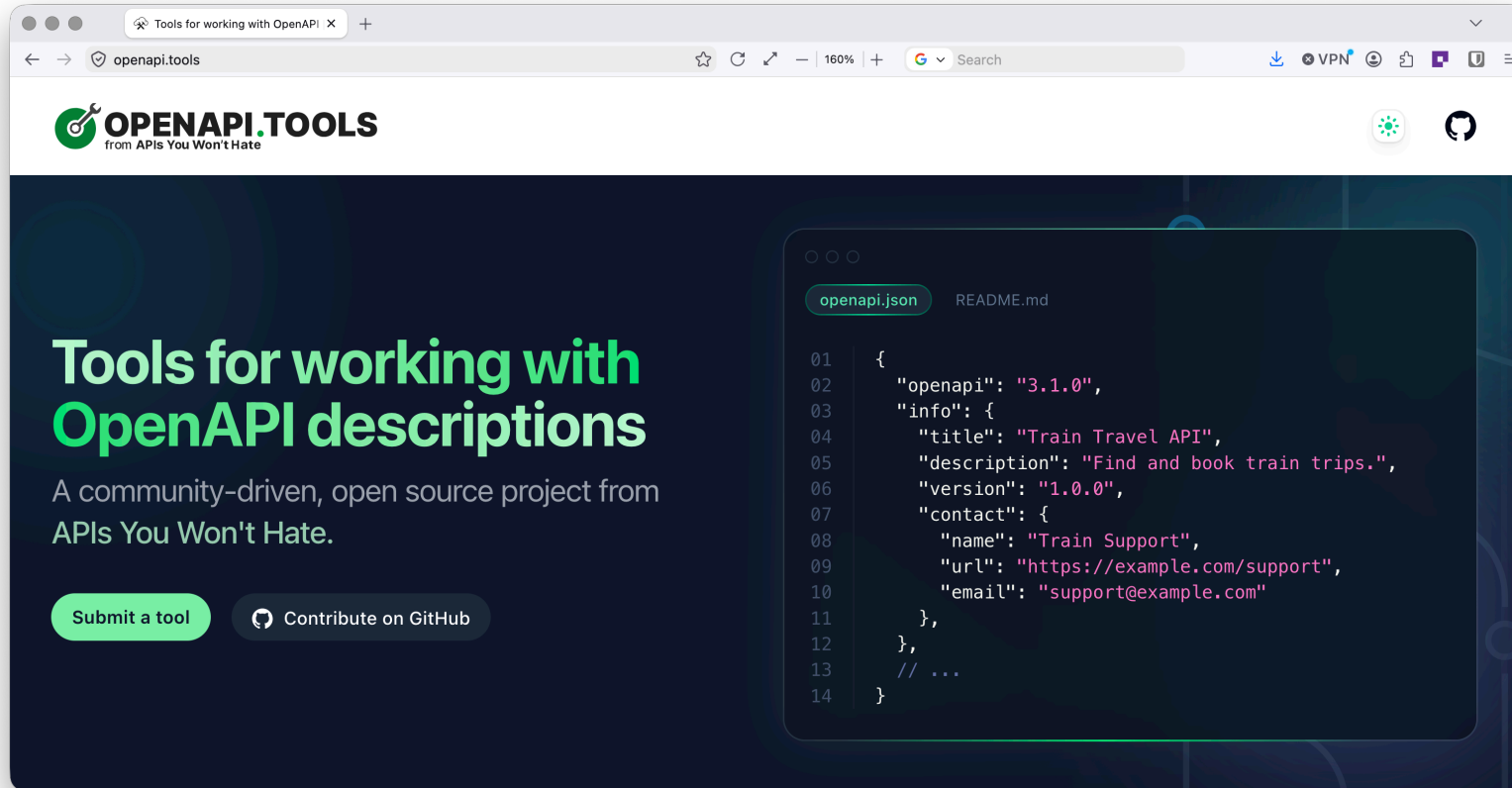


A Thin Layer, Not a Fat One

- Skip the API work → jump to MCP → call it “AI-readiness”
- MCP should be a *thin* layer, not a *fat* one
- Good APIs publish as MCP tools with little effort
- The rest need orchestration into tools worth calling
- Case in point: Meta Muse supports OpenAPI-based connectors



OpenAPI Tools



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Speed Is Pressure

- Internal teams build faster, or believe they have to
- Everyone outside builds more and expects you to keep up
- Most of that acceleration is outside your control
- Optionality is what decides how quickly you can respond



From Building Systems to Cultivating Open Ecosystems

- Point-to-point solutions solve today and constrain tomorrow
- Cultivating an ecosystem beats building one more system
- The value of *optionality* will continue to go up
- Always ask: does this let us reuse and experiment later?



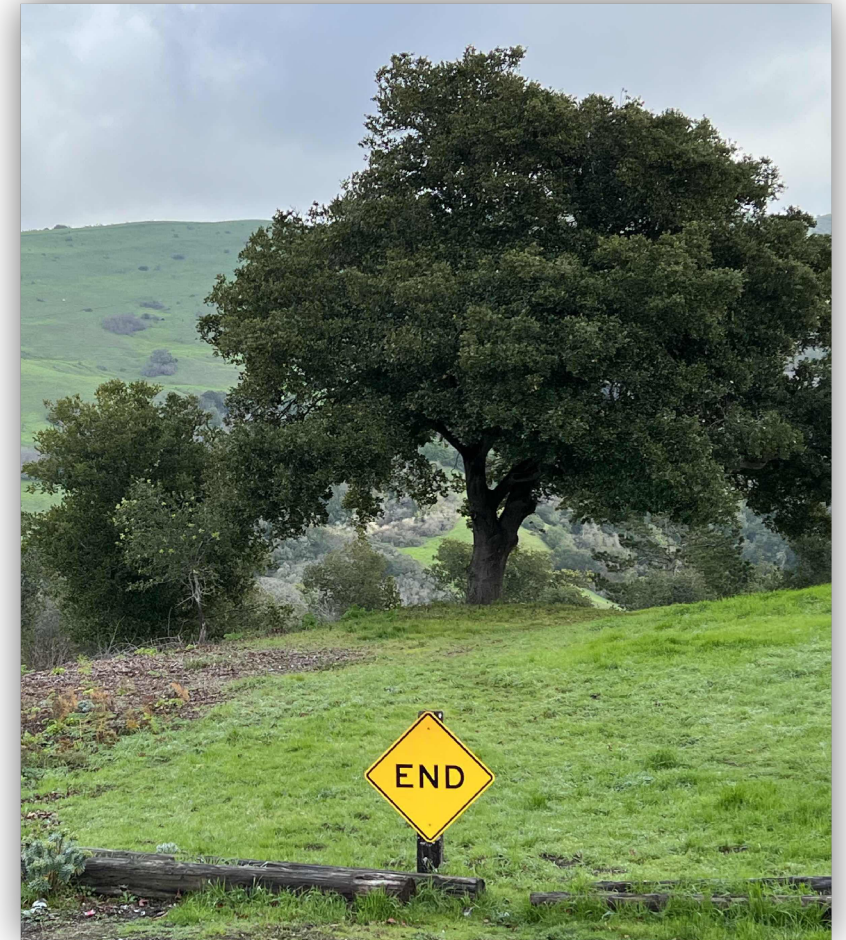
Monday Tasks

- Check APIs for AI readiness
- Check AI consumption for a proper management layer



Thank You!

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